By the Book

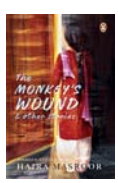
NEW TRANSLATIONS OF UNPUTDOWNABLE FICTION



VALLI
by Sheela Tomy; translated by Jayasree Kalathil
HARPER PERENNIAL
₹699; 420 pages
In a diary that Susan writes for her daughter Tessa, she tells the story of how her parents had once eloped. More crucially, though, she narrates the story of Kerala's Wayanad, a land of magic and rebellion.



BREAKING FREE
by Vaasanthi; translated by N. Kalyan Raman
HARPER PERENNIAL
₹399; 352 pages
Though Kasturi and Lakshmi are both born into the devadasi clan, they respond to their fate rather differently. In this newly translated Tamil masterpiece, we see one submit to duty and the other resist.



THE MONKEY'S WOUND AND OTHER STORIES
by Hajra Masroor; translated by Tahira Naqvi
PENGUIN MODERN CLASSICS
₹599; 340 pages
Translated from *Sab Afsanay Meray*, Hajra Masroor's seminal collection of Urdu short stories, we find in the 16 tales of this book characters and plots that seem brutal and delightful in equal measure.

BOOKS

KEEPING IT REAL

In this translation of Jeyamohan's work, we see the writer make literary a sometimes all too literal real



STORIES OF THE TRUE
by Jeyamohan; translated by Priyamvada Ramkumar
JUGGERNAUT
₹799; 328 pages

The prolific Tamil writer Jeyamohan will undoubtedly be known to future generations for the extraordinary work in which he is engaged. It is based on the Mahabharata—not a retelling or subversion, but a kind of digging down into every facet of every story in it, all interconnected with the history of Tamil culture and ideas. In short, it will be much longer than Vyasa's epic. For the moment, however, what is available to the reader in English from Jeyamohan's writings is the dozen narratives in *Stories of the True*, translated from a collection published in 2011 under the title *Aram*. Such a small number of stories cannot be representative of this writer's essays, travelogues, novels, and hundreds of short stories, but he seems to have laid his heart out here for all of us to see.

Jeyamohan is direct and declarative in introducing the collection. It is based on real persons and their stories. Some of the narratives read like long-form journalism, and in others, the writer adopts a first-person protagonist. The common element, Jeyamohan writes in his preface, is idealism, and the word *aram* encompasses virtue, ethics and dharma. Probably the most memorable story here is 'The Elephant Doctor', about the famous activist-veterinarian Dr V. Krishnamurthy of the Tamil Nadu forest department, and the lessons he teaches a young bureaucrat narrator entirely unready to encounter nature.

In the stories set in the grinding years just after Independence, when a civil service exam or even a clerkship pointed the way out of destitution, Jeyamohan sketches the complex interactions of caste, hunger, conversion, self-respect and self-rule. As the new widow says when she agrees to her husband's burial as a Christian, "For one whose belly is dry, all gods are but stone." One young protagonist or another finds liberation through a missionary, a swami, an Englishman, or even the owner of an eatery who feeds the starving without keeping count—the way a mother might, if the world were a better place. These individuals may win their way out of poverty, but they must fight the battles of caste every day, as the spit protocol of the old days evolves into sneers at the office. The cruellest story is that of the IAS officer who seems to have escaped the unspeakable oppressions of life as a Nayadi, only to be haunted by his terrified, terrifying mother, and the guilt of having run away from her.

Stories of the True is an unusually fluid translation, surprisingly the first major English translation of Jeyamohan's work. Still, no sensitive translator would hammer the exuberance of Tamil storytelling to fit an English reader's expectations, and the prose remains sometimes repetitive, often overwrought. But these are perhaps not stories to write, or read, in tranquility. ■

–Latha Anantharaman